

# The Decision I Need

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Dheirav

August 21, 2026

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### The question

A March 2026 theory paper proves the effect can go either way, with no experiments in it. I have the experiments and a rule you can actually apply. Is that an empirical paper worth publishing, or does it now read as a follow-up to someone else's result?

### Why it is a genuine fork

If the empirical half stands on its own, the paper is close to ready. Their paper proves the possibility and contains zero experiments. Mine has 26 measured arms from 15 populations, a controlled design, a rule computable from a historical approval rate, and the finding that **their conditions are satisfied on none of those 26 arms** — the quantity they are stated over diverges on real data. Theory and measurement then agree at a correlation of 0.93, having been arrived at independently.

If it now reads as derivative, that is a problem of framing rather than content, but it is still a problem. I reached this before knowing their paper existed — provable from dates — but a reader encountering both will see theirs first.

### What I would argue

The "when" is the contribution, and it stands on its own:

1. **Theory says it *can* go either way. Only measurement says *when*.** That is the gap, and it is the gap a practitioner is standing in.
2. **Their conditions do not work on data.** Zero of 26. That is a finding only someone with the experiments could have produced, and it is a contribution against the theory rather than an application of it.
3. **My rule is computable and theirs is not.** Theirs needs the joint distribution of the model's scores and group membership. Mine needs last year's approval rate.
4. **The practical reading is sharper than I first thought, and less comfortable.** I originally claimed loans, hiring and admissions are nearly all stingy systems, so the harmful direction is the usual one. **I measured it, and that was wrong** — they span the whole range and sit on both sides of the switch. The real practical claim is better: two products in the *same* mortgage market, run through the *same* fairness constraint, move in opposite directions, and the fairness report says success in both cases.

## The objection I expect

That this is now the empirical appendix to someone else's theory paper.

My answer: their conditions fail on every dataset I have, so this is not an application of their result — it is a demonstration that their result cannot be applied, plus a substitute that can. But I would rather be told now if that is too fine a distinction to carry a paper.

## Other questions, if there is time

1. **Which venue, and when?** The deadline decides the page limit, which decides how much of 16 research documents survives into the paper.
2. **One missing comparison.** The closest competing paper implements its fix a different way, and I have never run that version directly. About an hour of work. Worth doing?
3. **AI assistance.** I used an AI assistant substantially — for writing code, running analyses and drafting. What does the department expect me to disclose, and how?

## What is not in question

The measurements. Every headline number is regenerated from stored results by an automated check that fails if a document and its data disagree.

Three of my own predictions failed and are written up as failures. Two of my own claims were withdrawn. I would rather be told the framing is wrong now than find out in review — which is exactly what happened with the remedy, and why I no longer claim it as new.